

Callosciurus prevostii

Prevost's squirrel



Length 9³/₃₂–9¹/₂ in (23.7–24 cm)
Tail 9 in (23 cm)
Weight 13–14 oz (353–403 g)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



One of the most brightly colored mammals, this tree-dwelling, twilight-active squirrel is black on its upperparts and vivid chestnut-red on the underparts, with a broad, gleaming white band along each side from nose to

thigh. It lives alone or in small family groups, communicating by birdlike calls and visual displays of the bushy tail. The diet includes fruit, soft seeds, oily nuts, and buds, as well as termites, ants, grubs, and birds' eggs. After 46–48 days' gestation, the 2–3 young are born in a large nest of twigs and leaves, in a tree hole or among branches.



Sciurus vulgaris

Eurasian red squirrel



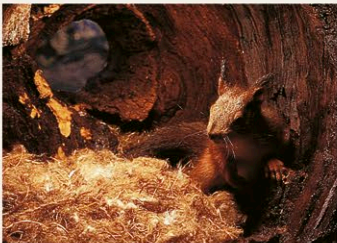
Length 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
Tail 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Weight 7–17 oz (200–475 g)
Location W. Europe to E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The “red” squirrel varies from red to brown, gray, or black on its back, and may turn gray-brown in winter. The underparts are always pale or white. An excellent climber and leaper, it feeds on the ground and in branches on seeds (especially those of conifers), nuts, mushrooms and other fungi, shoots,

fruit, soft bark, and sap. It lives alone except when

BREEDING NEST



The female red squirrel gives birth to 1–6 blind, naked babies. She nurses them for 12 weeks in the breeding nest, before they are weaned at 8–12 weeks. The nest may be a larger version of the ball-shaped, twig drey in a branch fork, or in a tree hole. It is lined with soft, fine material, to keep the young warm in her absence.

a female is nursing young, which she usually does once a year, although some females may produce two litters.



tail is about the same length as the head and body

BUSHY TAIL, TUFTED EARS

Although the red squirrel moults twice a year, the tail hair is only replaced once. Its ears are always tufted, particularly in winter.

feet are less hairy during the summer months

Sciurus carolinensis

Eastern gray squirrel



Length 8–12³/₁₆ in (20–31.5 cm)
Tail 6–10 in (15–26 cm)
Weight 11–25 oz (300–700 g)
Location S. and S.E. Canada to S. USA
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



Introduced from North America into parts of Europe, the eastern gray squirrel has a gray back and white or pale underparts. The face, back, and forelegs are brown-tinged. This opportunistic feeder takes nuts, seeds, flowers, fruit, buds, and fungi. It may emerge from its grass- and bark-lined twig nest (drey) in winter to forage. It also eats food that it stored during the autumn, locating it from memory and smell. Breeding occurs twice a year. The 2–4 young are helpless at birth, but grow quickly and are fully weaned at 10 weeks.

COLOR VARIATION

Despite their name, gray squirrels exhibit variation in fur color: some are black; others are reddish. These color forms belong to the same species and all can freely interbreed; coat color is passed on to offspring following a simple pattern of heredity. Fur color is determined by the distribution and types of chemical pigment in hair—including eumelanin (black pigment) and pheomelanin (reddish pigment). Reddish and black squirrels can arise anywhere in a “wild-type” gray population by random genetic mutation, and the color can spread as they pass their genes on when they breed. In North America, black squirrels are more common farther north because they retain heat better in cold climates.



SITTING PRETTY

When feeding on the ground, gray squirrels typically sit up in this way so that their forepaws are free to handle food items.



thick, bushy tail aids balance

paler fur on underside

Petaurista elegans

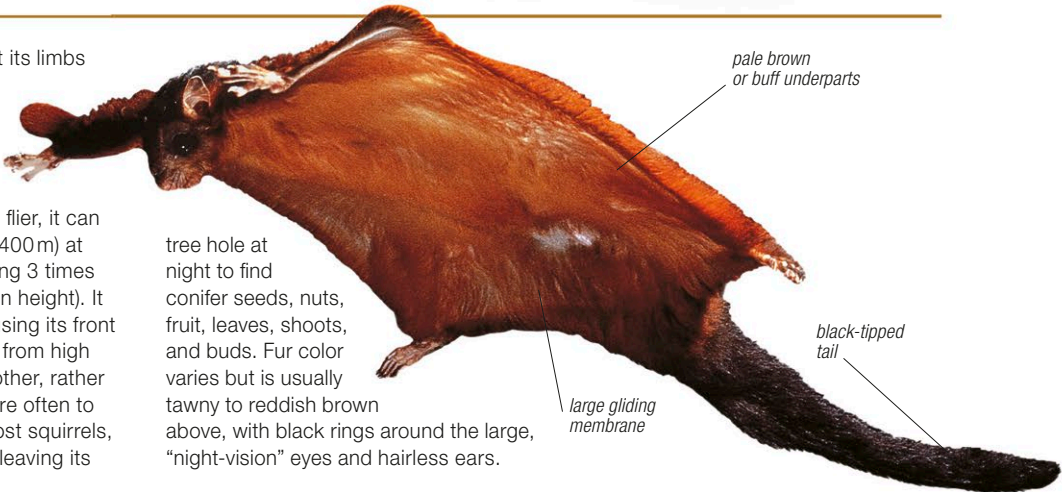
Spotted giant flying squirrel



Length 11³/₄–14³/₄ in (29.6–37.6 cm)
Tail 13¹/₂–16 in (34–40.5 cm)
Weight 1³/₄–3¹/₄ lb (0.8–1.6 kg)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



This squirrel stretches out its limbs to extend large patches of thin, loose, furred skin between front and rear legs, in a parachute-like shape. A glider rather than a true flier, it can travel more than 1,300 ft (400 m) at a 3-in-1 glide ratio (covering 3 times the distance that it loses in height). It changes the glide angle using its front legs. Glides are generally from high in one tree to lower in another, rather than to the ground, and are often to escape danger. Unlike most squirrels, this species is nocturnal, leaving its



pale brown or buff underparts

black-tipped tail

large gliding membrane

tree hole at night to find conifer seeds, nuts, fruit, leaves, shoots, and buds. Fur color varies but is usually tawny to reddish brown above, with black rings around the large, “night-vision” eyes and hairless ears.